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European Commission

Annual Activity Report 2024

DIRECTORATE-GENERAL FOR HUMAN RESOURCES AND SECURITY

Contents

DG HR IN BRIEF 3

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY 4

1. KEY RESULTS AND PROGRESS TOWARDS ACHIEVING THE COMMISSION'S GENERAL OBJECTIVES AND SPECIFIC OBJECTIVES OF THE DEPARTMENT 9

2. INTERNAL CONTROL AND FINANCIAL MANAGEMENT 25
   - 2.1. Control results 25
     - 2.1.1. Overview of the budget and relevant control systems (RCS) 25
     - 2.1.2. Effectiveness of controls 25
     - 2.1.3. Efficiency of controls 28
     - 2.1.4. Economy of controls 29
     - 2.1.5. Conclusion on the cost-effectiveness of controls 30
   - 2.2. Audit observations and recommendations 30
   - 2.3. Assessment of the effectiveness of internal control systems 32
   - 2.4. Conclusions on the assurance 33
   - 2.5. Declaration of Assurance 34

3. MODERNISING THE ADMINISTRATION 35
   - 3.1. Human resource management 35
   - 3.2. Digital transformation and information management 36
   - 3.3. Sound environmental management 37
   - 3.4. Examples of economy and efficiency 37

DG HR IN BRIEF

In line with Commission's corporate Human Resources (HR) strategy, DG HR aims at **modernising the Commission** and creating the right conditions for staff to deliver on the Commission's priorities ([1]).

DG HR's **values** are as follows, and consist of providing:

- Honest, fair, sustainable and ethical practice.
- Efficient, client-centric, high-quality human resources (HR) services.
- A positive, inclusive and respectful work environment.
- A flexible work environment that encourages teamwork, collaboration and innovation and promotes personal and professional development.
- Strengthened management capability across the Commission and a culture of high individual and team performance.
- An enshrined security culture.

In pursuing its mission, DG HR carries out the following **main types of activities**:

- ensuring a safe, green and healthy work environment where staff's physical and mental well-being is supported;
- supporting new, flexible ways of working with a focus on trust-based management;
- building a diverse, inclusive and accessible organisation;
- delivering efficient, staff-focused HR services supporting staff in all stages of their career;
- setting the strategic HR framework within an effective and efficient use of resources;
- adopting a forward-looking approach to ensure the Commission has the right skills to deliver on its priorities now and in the future;
- ensuring the safety, security and protection of staff, property, activities and information at all places of employment; and
- ensure full respect of the Staff Regulations and open and efficient social dialogue with staff representatives to guarantee adequate working conditions.

The **legal framework** regarding EU staff matters comprises the Treaty on the functioning of the European Union (TFEU), the Staff regulations of Officials (SR) and Conditions of Employment of Other Servants of the European Union (CEOS), delegated acts, EU directives, case law and report on the implementation of the Staff Regulations by all institutions. Sysper is the main HR management information system supporting most HR processes under the responsibility of DG HR. Work is however ongoing to develop a new user-friendly HR IT platform which will replace existing systems. In 2024, DG HR counted 1 330 statutory staff members ([2]). DG HR implemented its budget of EUR 418,29 million under centralised direct management. On 1 May 2024, Stephen Quest became the new Director-General.

([1]) As the new HR strategy was adopted after the publication of DG HR's strategic plan 2020-2024, the structure of this annual activity report has been adapted to align with the new HR strategy.

([2]) HR Key Figures 2024 'HR Key Figures 2024 (europa.eu)'

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

This annual activity report is a management report of the Director-General of DG Human Resources and Security (DG HR) to the College of Commissioners. Annual activity reports are the main instrument of management accountability within the Commission and constitute the basis on which the College takes political responsibility for the decisions it takes as well as for the coordinating, executive and management functions it exercises, as laid down in the Treaty on the functioning of the European Union ([3]).

Throughout 2024, DG HR continued to implement the actions from the corporate HR strategy adopted in 2022, to enable the Commission to perform at the highest level in the interest of all Europeans by offering a modern workplace and rewarding careers that attract top talent from all Member States. DG HR also progressed working toward the vision set out in the HR strategy in which all staff in the Commission work in a more trust-based, people-focused environment and following modern and flexible work practice.

A. Key results and progress towards achieving the Commission's general objectives and department's specific objectives

Specific objective 1: An attractive workplace for all

- Following the adoption of the Decision on prevention of and fight against harassment at the end of 2023 ([4]), DG HR started to implement the new policy. The new Chief Confidential Counsellor took office and began setting up a new network of confidential counsellors, launching awareness raising and training activities, and handling requests from colleagues who reported feeling harassed.
- DG HR continued to deliver on its commitment to promoting diversity and inclusion in the workplace, focusing especially on preparing the diversity and inclusion survey to be launched in 2025.
- DG HR strengthened the implementation of the Commission Decision on working time and hybrid working ([5]) by building on the 2023 evaluation.

Other key actions delivered in 2024 in support of objective 1:

Increased training on ethics; Set-up of a cross-DG AI change management team helping staff adapt to AI; A new green commuting policy for Brussels adopted; Increased registration scope of the Commission's eco-management and audit scheme to (Sofia, Copenhagen, and the Hague); Launch of awareness campaigns and training sessions supporting mental well-being.

([3]) Article 17(1) of the Treaty on the functioning of the European Union.
([4]) C(2023) 8630 final of 12 December 2023.
([5]) C(2020) 1788 final of 24 March 2022.

- A budget for a housing allowance for EU staff working and residing in Luxembourg was adopted and a memorandum of understanding was signed with the Luxembourg authorities on hospital prices to facilitate improved access to healthcare.
- DG HR continued implementing the Communication on greening the Commission and its action plan to achieve climate neutrality by 2030 ([6]).

Specific objective 2: Faster and agile selection and recruitment

- The Commission achieved gender balance in all management functions in 2024 (49% in December 2024).
- DG HR developed a new recruitment model which will start being implemented when the first reserve lists under the new competition model are published by the European Personnel Selection Office (EPSO) in 2025.
- Eight internal competitions were finalised, and four additional internal competitions were published.
- DG HR made progress on preparing the new Commission decision on the employment of temporary agents through a consultation process with trade unions.
- The blue book traineeship programme attracted more than 30 000 candidates, and the cohorts were geographically balanced. With a retention rate of around 25%, the programme represents an important recruitment pipeline.
- The 15 Member States' action plans on geographical balance were assessed, in collaboration with each Member State. The joint assessment reports contain statistics on Member States' presence in the Commission based on results indicators and output indicators contained in each action plan.

Specific objective 3: A flexible and rewarding career

- DG HR continued to explore options to improve staff mobility and identified a set of measures to address mobility challenges for different groups of staff.
- DG HR also continued to roll out a modernised and improved learning and development delivery model with seven new targeted learning packages per job profile.

Other key actions delivered in 2024 in support of objective 3:

Expanded staff exchange programme between executive agencies and their parent DGs; Continued cooperation with international partner organisations (e.g. United Nations and the World Bank) through exchanges of staff and best practice.

- DG HR began implementing the coaching strategy, shifting focus from individual to group coaching for more efficiency and impact.
- Training was provided for managers covering appraisal and managing staff performance.
- A new guide on managing probationary periods of staff was communicated to all Commission managers.

([6]) People first – Greening the European Commission - European Commission

Specific objective 4: Supporting the change

- DG HR continued to develop more efficient and streamlined HR processes by simplification, using digital tools and technologies to automate repetitive and time-consuming tasks, and standardising procedures and guidelines.
- The new integrated IT solution of the HR Service Desk went live and replaced the former Staff Matters portal and Staff Contact site.
- The new digital solution for the preselection module and the pilot solution for the onboarding module went live.

Specific objective 5: Foster a secure workplace

- The development of guidance to services on information assessment and categorisation.
- DG HR worked on horizontal information security risks related to handling sensitive non-classified information in AI systems, quantum computing, and outsourcing.
- DG HR continued to work on a draft proposal for a Commission decision on a security clearance requirement for certain categories of staff.
- The roll-out of a new digital tool that allows users to manage their accounts (RUE-X) for EU classified information.
- DG HR launched a new learning package addressed to Local Security Officers (LSOs) and deputy LSOs in the Commission, executive agencies and JRC sites, providing information on how to perform these tasks.

B. Key performance indicators

Result indicators	Baseline 2018	Interim results 2021	Target 2024	Latest known results 2023
Staff motivation index*	60%	62%	65%	63%
Staff satisfaction index*	66%	68%	70%	68%

* The staff motivation index measures the extent to which staff are motivated by the prospect of getting a job which better fits with their skills as well as being given more responsibility, a promotion, or other types of recognition. The staff satisfaction index measures how happy staff are with their working conditions and environment, promoting diversity, equality and staff well-being. The data comes from the Commission's staff survey in 2018, 2021 and 2023. The reference population has changed over time (the 2018 staff survey included non-staff such as service providers, which was not the case in 2021 and 2023 (following the new rules on service providers) in addition, Seconded National Experts were included in all years). The formulation of a few questions has also changed, which may have influenced the result. To facilitate a comparison, one question that was substantially changed has been removed from the calculation for all years.

Result indicators	Baseline 2019	Interim results 2022	Target 2024	Results 2024
Level of satisfaction with HR services: **Overall satisfaction** **Overall level of quality** **Satisfaction of staff** **Satisfaction of managers**	 68% 59% 69% 60%	 70% 63% 69% 71%	 >75% >75% >75% >75%	 74% 63% 69% 80%
Number of participants in security trainings and security briefings	8 149	8 500 (2023)	9 000	14 659
Average length of the recruitment process**				
When a medical visit is not needed	80% finalised within 30 calendar days	84% finalised within 30 calendar days 72% finalised within 21 calendar days	90% finalised within 14 calendar days	88% finalised within 30 calendar days 78% finalised within 21 calendar days 60% finalised within 14 calendar days
When medical visit is needed	80% finalised within 60 calendar days	76% finalised within 60 calendar days 14% finalised within 30 calendar days	80% finalised within 25 calendar days	84% finalised within 60 calendar days 21% finalised within 30 calendar days 10% finalised within 25 calendar days

** Several factors have an impact on the length of the recruitment process, especially an increased recruitment of TAs where the recruitment process is more complicated, increased overall recruitments, and an absence of IT automation tools. Recruitment visits are by definition more complex and sometimes require a case-by-case approach. The Medical Service continually revises and optimises its processes.

C. Key conclusions on internal control and financial management

DG HR has systematically examined the available control results and indicators, as well as the observations and recommendations issued by the Internal Audit Service (IAS) and the European Court of Auditors (ECA). These elements have been assessed to determine their impact on management's assurance about the achievement of the control objectives. Please refer to Section 2 for further details.

In conclusion, management has reasonable assurance that, overall, suitable controls are in place and working as intended; risks are being appropriately monitored and mitigated. Improvements are necessary in the areas of physical security of persons and assets in the Commission, the protection of confidentiality of information at corporate level and the assessment of HR needs in the Commission at corporate level. These result from key recommendations issued by the IAS in these specific areas. Mitigating actions have been implemented and continue to be reinforced, as detailed in Section 2.2. The Director-General, in his capacity as Authorising Officer by Delegation, has signed the Declaration of Assurance.

D. Provision of information to the Commissioner

In the context of the regular meetings during the year between DG HR and the Commissioner on management matters, the main elements of this report and assurance declaration have been brought to the attention of Commissioner Hahn, responsible for Budget and Administration in 2024, and Commissioner Serafin, responsible for Budget, Anti-Fraud and Public Administration for the period 2024-2029.

1. KEY RESULTS AND PROGRESS TOWARDS ACHIEVING THE COMMISSION'S GENERAL OBJECTIVES AND SPECIFIC OBJECTIVES OF THE DEPARTMENT

General objective 'A modern, high performing and sustainable European Commission'

1.1. Specific objective: An attractive workplace for all

1.1.1. An attractive workplace

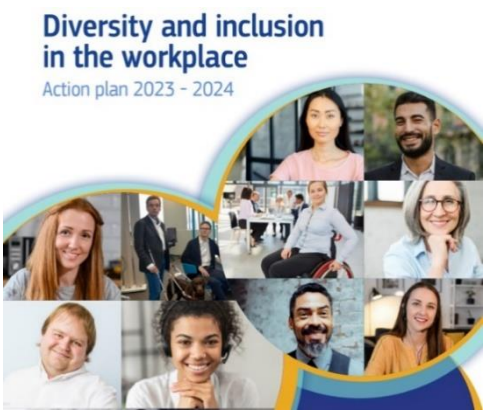
Ethical conduct is at the heart of the professionalism of Commission staff and ethics and integrity are an integral part of our organisational culture. In 2024, DG HR expanded its awareness-raising activities with a view to enhancing staff members' knowledge of and compliance with their ethical obligations. Notably, DG HR organised more than 80 training sessions (up from 63 in 2023) targeting staff at all levels, including senior and middle managers and tailor-made training for services with higher risks. The number of requests for authorisations also grew substantially (for example for outside activities, and spouse employment), pointing to an enhanced awareness of ethical obligations. Moreover, the Commission continued to lead regular interinstitutional exchanges on ethical matters with representatives of all other EU institutions and bodies. This has been crucial in helping the Institution to further enhance the robustness of its ethical framework and to share and learn from best practice from across the EU institutions.

The **Chief Confidential Counsellor**, nominated in the Decision on the Commission's new anti-harassment policy ([7]), took up her function on 1 September 2024. To implement the new anti-harassment policy and its action plan, the selection of a new network of confidential counsellors has been launched and the 25 confidential counsellors will form this new network. Awareness raising of the new anti-harassment policy has been launched by the Chief Confidential Counsellor with information sessions offered to all Directorates-General of the Commission. The Decision foresees that managers undergo



([7]) C(2023) 8630 final of 12 December 2023.

mandatory training on anti-harassment, and the first online training for Heads of Unit with up to 200 participants took place on 9 December 2024. During her first four months in office, the Chief Confidential Counsellor received 123 requests for confidential advice, information on available services, and support.



DG HR continued to deliver on its commitment to promoting **diversity and inclusion in the workplace** ([8]). There was a particular focus on data collection with preparations to repeat the diversity and inclusion survey first conducted in 2021. Data protection and other technical issues were also addressed as part of preparations to introduce a diversity monitoring tool in HR IT systems. Technical work has been completed for introducing non-binary gender options in IT systems, but implementation is dependent on resolving reporting and other knock-on effects. Digital accessibility has been put at the centre of the design of new IT systems and interfaces and work has continued to improve physical accessibility to our premises. In addition, DG HR has continued to promote learning and development and awareness raising, with a repeat of the diversity and inclusion awards and events to mark key dates in the international calendar. Finally, a series of practical workshops have been rolled out to Commission managers to increase awareness of the benefits of diversity and offer managers practical tools for improving the inclusive work culture in their teams.

Regarding the **attractiveness of the Luxembourg site**, the adoption of a budget for a housing allowance for certain EU staff working and residing in Luxembourg in November 2024 after lengthy negotiations was a breakthrough. Pending the adoption of the Commission Decision and the finalisation of operational considerations ensuring, equal implementation across all participating EU institutions, bodies and agencies in Luxembourg, both expected early 2025, the allowance is due to be paid retroactively as of 1 January 2025.

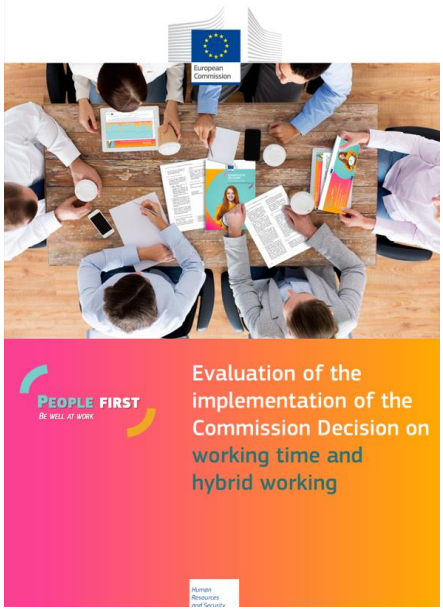
In November 2024, after years of stalled discussions on the subject, Commissioner Hahn signed a **memorandum of understanding with the Luxembourg authorities on hospital prices**. The aim is to facilitate improved access to healthcare by introducing more transparent tariffs and direct billing for the joint sickness insurance scheme (JSIS) affiliates, to be implemented in the course of 2025 and 2026.

Regarding the 12 actions of the **interinstitutional high-level initiative**, the working groups, and particularly the excellence hubs, organised successful activities such as summer schools, conferences and study visits, to attract and retain talent with specific profiles which EU institutions in Luxembourg need urgently. A financing mechanism for the excellence hubs has been agreed by the Heads of Administration in Luxembourg in 2024.

([8]) Diversity and inclusion - European Commission

The interinstitutional job platform for temporary staff, to facilitate mobility onsite, has been fully rolled out in 2024.

In 2024, DG HR made significant progress in strengthening the implementation of the Commission Decision on **working time and hybrid working** ([9]), which has been in force since April 2022. Building on the findings of the 2023 evaluation, DG HR focused on actions within its control to enhance team cohesion and optimise the hybrid working model. Key achievements include: 1) implementing the follow-up action plan addressing the main recommendations from the 2023 evaluation; 2) development of comprehensive guidance to assist staff departments in navigating hybrid working arrangements effectively; and 3) drawing up a register of tasks incompatible with teleworking (Working Time and Hybrid Working) to guide staff and managers in determining the compatibility of certain tasks in their job descriptions with teleworking.



Challenges in 2024 included adapting these actions to diverse team needs and ensuring consistent implementation across all departments. External factors such as rapid technological changes and varying levels of digital literacy among staff has impacted progress. Despite these challenges, the department's actions contributed to broader Commission objectives by creating a flexible and efficient working environment that aligns with the principles of modern workplace management.

The **Flexible Working Change team**, consisting of staff members from DG HR, the Office for Infrastructure and Logistics in Brussels (OIB), the Office for Infrastructure and Logistics in Luxembourg (OIL), DG for Digital Services (DIGIT), DG Interpretation (SCIC), the Secretariat-General (SG) and the Joint Research Centre (JRC), supported those DGs and services that moved into flexible workspaces in 2024 with a package of change management support. It included workshops, presentations, training (lunchtime conferences), tailored advice, hands-on support during the moves, and post-move evaluation exercises (100-day stocktaking). This was supported by complementary measures such as open days, guided visits and communication through corporate channels to all staff. As this is a rolling programme of support, first steps have been taken in the process to accompany the next DGs that will move in 2025 and 2026. Additionally, work was undertaken to understand trends, successes and challenges related to the flexible workplace, notably by an in-depth analysis of the 2023 staff survey results relating to flexible working, and through a dedicated pulse survey run in November 2024 on flexible working in flexible offices.

([9]) C(2020) 1788 final of 24 March 2022.

In its second year after being mandated in February 2023, the **Centre for Organisational Transformation** (a multi-disciplinary team of 35 colleagues from DG HR, JRC, SG, DG DIGIT and DG Communications, Networks, Content and Technology) has advanced on its key objective of transforming the European Commission into a more collaborative working environment. As 2024 marked a transition year to the new Commission, the Centre prepared dedicated training, guidance and process efficiency solutions for new Cabinets. A modern digital working approach is being implemented for the new Cabinets with collaborative SharePoint Online workspaces, Teams telephony, and enhanced meeting tools. Efforts involve cross-departmental collaboration, with progress shown in consulting 19 of 26 Cabinets in the first week. Positive feedback highlights the success of the workspaces, paperless processes, and automated workflows. Key guidance 'Which EC tool to use for what' and two new corporate trainings (Teams all you need to know and Demo: From Teams to SharePoint Online) have been made available for all staff. The Centre offered a 'Summer School 2024: Improving the way we work together' that gathered a total of 4 000 registrations, with participants attending multiple sessions.

In September 2024, a cross-DG **AI change management team** was set up under the umbrella of the Centre with the aim of helping staff adapt to the increasing presence of AI tools and options via three main actions: gathering testimonials, nominating AI champions and assisting DGs in setting targets for their desired level of AI tool use. The Centre also launched a hub, called innovative practice, which aims at introducing and connecting innovative initiatives from various parts of the Commission that are driving greater efficiency and having an impact in both public policy and internal working methods. In the follow-up to the 2023 staff survey, DG HR and the Centre for Organisational Transformation were in active contact with line-DGs/services, helping them interpret their results, identify their needs and reflect on how these might be addressed, involving both management and staff as appropriate.



In addition to these corporate initiatives, the Centre continued to provide its on-request **consultancy services**, responding to over 160 specific requests from client DGs, e.g.: The internal consultants of the Centre supported requesting DGs/services in designing and facilitating appropriate follow-up events to the staff survey and other strategic processes. To deal with the high demand for hosting client events, the Centre has also continued to offer training events for staff across the Commission to build capacity and further grow the community of internal facilitators and organisational development practitioner.

Throughout 2024, the Commission continued implementing the **Communication on greening the Commission** ([10]) and its action plan, to achieve climate neutrality by 2030. The Commission reported on its implementation and progress towards the greening targets through its annual environmental statement, published end 2024 (based on 2023 data).



A new **green commuting policy** ([11]) for Commission staff in Brussels was adopted on 7 July 2024, setting out how even more colleagues could be encouraged to come to work by public transport, or to cycle or walk. It entered into force on 1 January 2025 and promotes active commutes as part of a healthy lifestyle and a benefit for the environment. DG HR continued its work on the new guide to missions, expected to be adopted during Q2 2025. DG HR continued to work with OIB and OIL on the transition towards smart and sustainable offices and reduced office space, in line with the New European Bauhaus, whilst continuing close cooperation with the Brussels region on mobility, security, and staff well-being. DG HR also continued its internal preparations for the progress review of the greening of the Commission, expected to be adopted end 2025.

The Commission increased its **eco-management and audit scheme** (EMAS) registration scope to three additional Commission representations, in Sofia, Copenhagen and the Hague. Throughout 2024, DG HR ran an intensive programme of internal communication and staff engagement activities ([12]) and outreach towards external stakeholders.

In line with the Commission's corporate **internal communication** action plan, the overhaul of the Commission intranet has been almost completed. 90% of the sites (homesite, corporate thematic hubs and local DG intranets) transitioned to the new technology improving the user experience, findability of information, and integrating internal communication and collaboration. To further boost staff engagement, with the launch of the new homesite in June 2024, the internal social platform was also modernised. Throughout 2024, DG HR continued to lead the domain of internal communication, animating the community and carrying out intensive campaigns on several topics, such as flexible working, well-being of staff, adoption of the renewed anti-harassment framework, greening and career development opportunities to accompany the implementation of the HR strategy.



A multidisciplinary project team of DG HR, EPSO and DG DIGIT continued to develop a **single candidate portal**. The new portal will allow external candidates to see multiple opportunities and provide them with a consolidated and clear view of the benefits of working for an EU institution, body or agency. It will facilitate communication between

([10]) People first – Greening the European Commission - European Commission
([11]) C(2024) 4802 final of 7 July 2024.
([12]) https://eceuropaeu.sharepoint.com/sites/greening

candidates and HR recruiting services through automated notifications and updates on the status of applications, interview schedules and other relevant information. For candidates, the time and effort to fill out job applications will be reduced as they will be able to reuse saved profile data and previously entered information (the 'once-only' principle).

1.1.2. Ensuring staff well-being and satisfaction

DG HR has supported the Commission's general objective through various efforts by fostering a healthy, adaptable, and inclusive workplace, ultimately contributing to higher levels of staff satisfaction and improved performance. In 2024, DG HR continued to advance the **health and well-being strategy**, navigating both internal and external challenges. DG HR coordinated and implemented actions focused on physical and mental well-being, both in office and remote work settings. Key results include:

- **Mental well-being culture promotion**: DG HR launched awareness campaigns and training sessions aimed at destigmatising mental health issues. This included workshops on resilience, stress management, and mindfulness practice as well as continuing the training of Mental Health First Aiders holding 32 courses for 250 participants. DG HR has also launched Be Well Telecare, a telephone service which offers a first point of contact to staff who may be experiencing loneliness, anxiety, stress or other mental health issue at work.
- **Absence/Sickness Management Enhancements**: Further guidance has been published to better support the reintegration process at work after long-term sick leave. A new decision on absence and sickness management has been drafted, proposing standard procedures and simplification. The draft decision is currently being discussed internally, before further validation, consultation and adoption planned for 2025.
- **Inclusive Health Initiatives**: Targeted programmes and campaigns (e.g. Mental Health Week, Self-Care days and BeWell@My workplace, Fitness Days) addressed the diverse needs of staff in Brussels, Luxembourg and on JRC sites. Initiatives included ergonomic assessments and fitness challenges.

In 2024, DG HR continued to work on reinforcing its **health and safety management system** to contribute to the well-being of staff, based on a gap analysis by reference to the requirements of ISO 45001, the international standard for occupational health and safety management systems. DG HR relaunched actions to raise managerial awareness of the prevention of psycho-social risks. DG HR finalised and started implementing an action plan on first intervention (fire prevention, evacuations and first aid), together with OIB and OIL, considering new flexible working conditions. DG HR also prepared a global annual report on health and safety, harmonised across all sites.

DG HR has continued exchanging best practice in HR matters with Member States, international organisations and third countries notably through the **European Network for Public Administration (EUPAN)**, Public Administration Reform Special Groups with candidate and potential candidate countries, and through enhanced partnerships with key

partner organisations such as United Nations and World Bank. In 2024, DG HR supported Member States' efforts to organise EUPAN exchanges at political level and contributed to the EUPAN ministerial meeting organised by the Belgian Presidency, in Ghent in February. Furthermore, DG HR attended EUPAN meetings at Director-General level in Brugge and Budapest, under the Belgian and Hungarian presidencies respectively and had constructive exchanges on HR priority topics such as evidence-based policy making, greening, artificial intelligence, and attractiveness of public administration as employer. DG HR also participated in staff exchanges with other EUPAN members on hybrid working, greening and digital technologies in the civil service.

To consolidate **partnerships in HR matters** with peer international organisations, in 2024, DG HR conducted a study visit to the United Nations Secretariat focused on exchanging best practice on careers. DG HR participated in the dialogue on public administration reforms with countries preparing for the EU accession, through annual meetings of public administration reform special groups as well as in the screening of public administration with Moldova and Ukraine and has provided examples of best practice in the areas of human resources management.

DG HR ensures harmonisation of HR rules and policies in **executive and decentralised agencies and joint undertakings**. It assists agencies on specific policies and shares expertise and best practice. DG HR participated in the EU Agencies Network meetings in Brussels and Budapest providing insights on, among others, implementing rules to the Staff Regulations, diversity and inclusion, developments on HR transformation. Following the adoption by the Commission of new rules on anti-harassment, DG HR engaged with agencies in the preparation of a specific model decision for them. DG HR contributed to the Commission opinions on single programming documents of decentralised agencies and continued emphasising the objectives behind greater female representation in management and for environmental management. DG HR continued supporting agencies and other EU institutions in their efforts to pool resources by providing a large range of services through service level agreements (medical services, trainings, Sysper, HRT, etc.).

European Schools offer high standard quality education, crucial for attracting qualified staff to the European institutions, bodies and agencies. The Commission (represented by DG HR) plays a key and active role representing the European institutions in the governance of the European Schools, notably in the context of the opening of the 5th European School in Brussels, scheduled for September 2030, and reshaping the landscape of the European Schools in Brussels. In addition, the Commission continues to support European Schools in their efforts to strengthen their financial management. Notably, in 2024, the Board of Governors of the European Schools adopted an action plan as a follow-up to various EP recommendations. The Commission again played an active role in the elaboration of the action plan that includes elements under the Commission's responsibility such as the place and role of the European Schools in the European Education Area.

1.2. Specific objective: Fast and agile selection and recruitment

1.2.1. Faster and agile selection and recruitment

In 2024, DG HR developed a **new recruitment model** which will be implemented as of 2025, when the first reserve lists under the new EPSO competition model will be published. Under the new recruitment model, the recruitment of laureates from reserve lists will be carried out in a decentralised manner by the recruiting services, with DG HR participating in the recruitment panels to map the laureates' general skills and abilities (that are no longer tested by EPSO). The new recruitment model has been designed to further leverage and expand on the new EPSO competition model, where longer lists of laureates will be available, while ensuring swift and flexible recruitment procedures.



Throughout 2024, DG HR advanced on the finalisation of the adoption process for the new **Commission decision on the employment of temporary agents**, consulting with the trade unions and reflecting on potential final adjustments. The draft decision streamlines and harmonises the selection and recruiting processes and enhances transparency in requiring all vacant posts to be published externally and offers further clarity on the duration of the contracts and grading. Pending the adoption of a new decision, DG HR paused the review of the General Implementing Provisions (GIPs) governing the recourse to contract staff. The future review of the GIPs should take stock of the implementation of the temporary agents' decision and be included in the elaboration of an improved recruitment and talent management, as part of the priorities defined in the mission letter of the new Commissioner for the EU public administration.

By the end of 2024, DG HR finalised all six **internal competitions** published in 2023 resulting in a total of 430 laureates. In addition, two competitions (AST1 for Irish linguistic assistants and AST3 opened to AST and AST/SC officials and temporary agents who want to accede to the higher function group), both published and delivered in 2024, resulted in 108 laureates. Advanced planning and the timely availability of selection board members facilitated the delivery of these competitions throughout the year. In 2024, DG HR also published another six new internal competitions: AST/SC2, AST1 (for linguistic assistants), AST2, AST3, AD5 and AD6. The AD5 competition allowed AD temporary staff to become officials and is also part of the annual cycle allowing junior professionals to participate in at least one internal competition during their journey in the junior professional's programme. The AST/SC2, AST2 and AD6 competitions are open to officials, temporary agents and contract agents, whereas the AST3 competition has been opened to AST and AST/SC officials and temporary agents who would like to accede to the higher function group. DG HR also published two TA selection procedures.

The **junior professionals programme** ([13]) continued to be a large success attracting over 1750 applications for a total of 50 places (two exercises took place in 2024). The November 2024 intake had the highest ever number of applicants (968). Since its opening to executive agencies in April 2023, one candidate from an executive agency has been admitted to the junior professionals programme during two of the last three exercises (in November 2023 and April 2024). DG HR will continue to monitor the programme, including its extension to executive agencies in view of using the experience gained over the last exercises to further refine the programme and, possibly, initiate during 2025 first discussions with the other institutions to assess the feasibility of an interinstitutional programme.

The **blue book traineeship programme** ([14]) continued to be a successful flagship programme, attracting more than 15 000 candidates for each of the two annual sessions. DG HR saw a growing number of non-EU candidates, even if the number of non-EU trainees remains low (around 20 per session). The cohorts are geographically balanced and with a retention rate of around 25% represent an important recruitment pipeline. Diversity and inclusion surveys conducted annually with all the EU candidates show that the programme remains attractive and inclusive across young graduates' diverse backgrounds. DG HR will continue to monitor and refine the execution and the overall concept of the programme, based on trainees' and recruiters' needs and expectations.



To facilitate the **transition to the new College**, the Cabinets were successfully and timely staffed when the new College took up office on 1 December 2024. Offboarding and onboarding procedures and other working methods were updated, and digitised where possible. A new Decision on the composition of Cabinets was adopted.

1.2.2. Balanced, diverse and flexible composition of staff

At the beginning of the Commission mandate 2019-2024, President von der Leyen announced her commitment to reaching **gender balance** at all management levels by the end of 2024. Over this period, DG HR has played a key role in ensuring that this strong political commitment could translate into specific targets, concrete actions and binding measures to support women in their endeavours to pursue a management career, while providing ample opportunities for men to do the same. These concerted efforts resulted in a 49% female representation in management. The Commission now has, among public administrations in Europe, and around the world, the highest share of women in leadership positions.

([13]) e72f766c-3ef9-408a-a03f-e2b1f132f368_en
([14]) EC Blue Book Traineeship programme - European Commission

Work on strategic **workforce planning** continued with a particular focus on skills mapping. DG HR conducted a skills mapping exercise to analyse the current stock and future skills needs in the European Commission in the coming five years. This mapping, in consultation with the HR Correspondents, covers a range of skills (e.g. transversal, digital, green etc.) with a dedicated section on AI. DG HR developed an EU survey to assess these skills needs, the results of which are being compiled and analysed. In collaboration with relevant units, these will inform policies in relation to learning and development and recruitment. DG HR established an interinstitutional working group on skills with the objective of defining a skills-based organisation and finding out how each institution may become a skills-based organisation. This is to be integrated into the ongoing construction of the HRT platform. An initial brainstorming meeting has taken place, and work is continuing. DG HR continued its policy discussion on the evolution of the AST/SC function group including consideration of an amended AST/SC job profile to better reflect the current nature of work. DG HR also participated in the EPSO taskforce on skills needs for the forthcoming AST/SC competitions.

DG HR assessed, in collaboration with each Member State, the action plans on **geographical balance**. DG HR assessed, in collaboration with each of the 15 under-represented Member States, the joint action plans on geographical balance. The joint assessment reports included statistics on Member States' presence in the Commission based on results indicators and output indicators contained in each joint action plan, as well as agreed conclusions. In addition, statistics on all Member States' presence across grades in the Commission, including disaggregated management data, was provided to the Council Working Party on Staff Regulation, at the request of the Presidencies. The Commission is preparing the legal basis for the introduction of additional measures (General Implementing Provisions of Article 27 of the Staff Regulations). This will provide a robust legal framework and the continuation of a sustainable and step-by-step approach to improving geographical balance. DG HR provided to all Member States a presentation on the draft General Implementing Provisions to provide for additional measures on geographical balance.

1.3. Specific objective: A flexible and rewarding career

1.3.1. Flexible careers

Increasing **staff mobility** within the Commission and establishing a more positive narrative around mobility is key to remaining an attractive and relevant administration. In 2024, DG HR explored various options to improve mobility across different staff categories and to deliver on the commitment in the HR strategy on promoting regular internal and external mobility at all levels in all places of employment. Following strategic guidance from the Corporate Management Board and discussions with Directors-General and Resource Directors, DG HR has identified a set of measures to address mobility challenges for the various groups of staff: senior managers, middle managers, other officials comprising AD, AST, AST/SC, and temporary and contract agents. DG HR will finalise the policy paper and launch measures in 2025.

The 2024 rotation and **mobility exercise for EU Delegations** was successfully closed, and DG HR completed the first phase of the 2025 mobility exercise in January 2025. The usual timetable has is slightly delayed due to ongoing strategic discussion about the future EU Delegations network.

Following the success for the pilot **staff exchange programme between executive agencies and their parent DGs**, expanding the mobility opportunities for staff, further participants joined the programme in 2024, specifically JRC, OIB and the Paymaster Office (PMO). Over 70 projects of common interests have been proposed and 140 colleagues applied for exchanges aiming at reinforcing knowledge in specific areas of work.



Cooperation with key **international partner organisations** such as United Nations and the World Bank has continued in 2024 through exchanges of staff and best practice. Nine Commission staff members benefitted from the staff exchange programme in 2024. For the first time, the programme was open to temporary and contracts agents in addition to officials. A new administrative arrangement on exchanges of staff and best practice has been signed with the African Union Commission, which would allow this organisation to be included in the list of partners for staff exchanges in 2025. In parallel, exchanges of best practice with partner organisations have intensified around HR topics such as careers support, mobility, reform programmes etc.

DG HR rolled out a modernised and improved learning and development delivery model, centred around targeted **learning packages** per job profiles, covering more than 80% of Commission staff. These packages consist of modules that cater for the skills and competencies needed to deliver on the Commission's strategic and political priorities and provide guidance to staff to help them achieve a meaningful career. In 2024, DG HR completed the job profiles by adding learning packages for: interpretation, external audit, economics, law, statistics, infrastructure and logistics and security to the 13 packages published in 2022 and 2023. The handbook for managers explaining how to use these packages for their staff was updated in time for the next appraisal period. Following a consultation of all DGs and services, the Commission's learning priorities were reviewed in early 2024, and in autumn 2024 an in-depth review was launched to take account of the 2024-2029 Commission political guidelines.

2024 was the first year of implementing the **coaching strategy** and its action plan, switching focus from individual to group coaching for more efficiency and impact. To better address organisational needs and contribute to a culture of trust, inclusion and collaboration, group coaching programmes were introduced for specific target populations, including team managers, senior managers, and middle managers for more systemic impact. This facilitates the growth of leadership and people management competencies in these key roles.

Several career support measures were implemented and further refined in 2024 to enhance the efficacy and harmonisation of career development support provided to staff. Nearly 3 000 **career guidance** sessions were conducted with more than 1 800 staff members. This included the 4 Year Career Talks and Newcomers Career Talks, which attracted new clients, promoted a culture of mobility and ensured a steady promotion of HR services. Satisfaction with the service remained high, with 91% of participants finding the service useful and approximately 93% recommending this form of support.

Individual career guidance sessions were complemented by a broad range of **career-related learning** opportunities, including dedicated sessions on skills assessment and development, interview preparation, CV/cover letter drafting, and self-reflective workshops. Based on an evaluation and analysis of the individual sessions, tailor-made sessions were introduced for specific function groups and populations, including a workshop addressing needs and concerns of non-permanent staff. Additionally, a dedicated project team was set up to explore the opportunities offered by AI tools to enhance both the career-related learning offer and individual sessions. In total, throughout 2024, almost 50 group sessions were organised for over 2 200 staff members.

The annual **Career Days** took place in June, offering almost 100 workshops, training sessions and webinars focused on career development and learning opportunities. The event was open to Commission staff across all sites and to colleagues working in EU delegations and executive agencies. Over half of all sessions were organised in person, creating opportunities for networking and staff engagement.



The learning service continued to facilitate mobility in the Commission's workforce in 2024 by supporting line managers in identifying relevant candidates for specific posts, including vacancies with a high strategic importance for the Commission. Artificial intelligence solutions were incorporated to assist in headhunting and job-hunting processes, in compliance with Commission guidelines on AI use. The HR Search Tool, used in the headhunting process, was expanded to a wider audience of HR professionals, to widen the scope of qualified users who have a better insight into relevant profiles and skillsets in particular services. To foster internal staff mobility at all levels, DG HR further promoted the use of the interactive Career Paths Dashboard. The dashboard assisted users in planning their career path and was used by HR professionals in supporting staff in effective career management. DG HR also hosted the opening and closing events of the second interinstitutional job shadowing exercise – an initiative driven by the European School of Administration (EUSA) to foster the culture of idea exchange and experiences across EU Institutions and agencies.

1.3.2. Performance management

An ad hoc **Task Force on Team Managers** evaluated the needs of support team managers (Deputy Heads of Unit, Heads of Sector and Team Leaders) in their current role, and on their future career path. Three working groups analysed existing support and gaps, the relevance of setting up network(s) and the design of a new management development programme for future middle managers. As follow-up, Commission-wide networks were launched for Deputy Heads of Unit and Team Managers and a revamped management talent development programme for future middle managers was endorsed to be launched in 2025.



Greater visibility is now given to the assistance provided to managers and HR Correspondents by the Performance Management Team in DG HR when individual performance issues are identified. The Performance Management Team worked in close coordination with the career guidance and coaching services, the medical service, and other concerned services in DG HR, providing advice and operational support on early remediation of performance issues, appraisal, probation, and drafting of support plans. It also ran the proceedings of the Joint Reports Committee and Joint Advisory Committee on Professional Incompetence. Highly appreciated training was provided for managers covering appraisal and **managing staff performance**. Awareness-raising on the importance of timely remediation of any underperformance issue and the responsibility of managers in the effective follow-up of all probationers were also included in the regular induction sessions organised for newly appointed Heads of Unit.

The new guide for managers on **managing probationary periods** of staff was communicated to all Commission managers, following its endorsement by the Corporate Management Board in December 2023. The guide supports awareness-raising for managers on their responsibility to ensure high quality recruitments and adequate follow-up of all probationary periods. Throughout 2024, DG organised training sessions for managers in 23 DGs and executive agencies, with over 700 participants so far. This training will continue to be deployed in other Commission DGs in 2025. In addition, each newly appointed middle manager was contacted to discuss their probationary period and offered support from DG HR. Their progress is closely followed, including monitoring of their probation reports and management training, and followed up with the HR Correspondents where there is a need for remediation.

1.4. Specific objective: Supporting the change: towards staff-focused and efficient HR services

1.4.1. Refining the HR model towards staff-focused HR services

To **modernise and improve HR services** to staff, DG HR applies the approach of business process optimisation. By linking digital tools, processes and where necessary organisational changes, DG HR aims to make HR services more accessible, efficient, and user-friendly. Key features include new online self-service tools; better support for career development, mobility, and training; and an improved user experience for the digital services.

1.4.2. Easy access to information and support with the HR Helpdesk

The **HR Service Desk** has continued to see a significant increase in the number of users, particularly since its phone number was integrated to the PMO's single phone number system, streamlining call dispatches and routing by topic. The positive feedback on the service confirms a high level of client satisfaction, underscoring the continued need for direct human interaction and personalised, coordinated support that complements technological developments, rather than being replaced by them.

The **new integrated IT solution** of the HR Service Desk went live in June 2024 and replaced the former Staff Matters portal and the Staff Contact service. It is hosted on the ServiceNow engagement platform and serves active staff in the Commission, the pensioners, and all other people who benefit from the PMO's services. In total, there are nearly 70 000 people across all institutions plus 30 000 pensioners benefitting from the new service.

1.4.3. Ensuring efficient and streamlined HR processes

DG HR has continued to develop more efficient and streamlined HR processes through:

- **Process simplification**: process experts together with the HR business units review and simplify HR processes to eliminate redundant steps and reduce complexity, making them more user-friendly and efficient for staff members. This involves identifying bottlenecks and streamlining processes to ensure faster service delivery.
- **Automation**: digital tools and technologies help to automate repetitive and time-consuming tasks, such as data entry, document processing, and reporting. This reduces the risk of errors and frees up HR staff to focus on higher value tasks.
- **Standardisation**: standardised procedures and guidelines for HR processes ensure consistency and reduce variations in service delivery. This promotes better collaboration and knowledge sharing among HR teams and helps to build a cohesive 'people first' culture.

1.4.4. Using technology to enhance HR services for the user

The **HR transformation (HRT) programme** is the 7-year flagship IT programme to optimise HR processes and improve the quality of HR delivery with the help of digital tools and platforms. HRT's scope has been extended to more than 150 000 staff and pensioners in the Commission and other institutions, bodies and agencies.

HRT **digitally transforms and modernises the services** of the entire HR family (DG HR, the PMO, EPSO, OIB and OIL). It aims to revamp core services in selection and recruitment capabilities (together with EPSO and PMO services) and improve career and performance management, staff support and working conditions. It will also help improve services of the PMO such as payroll and health insurance and better connect with logistical and building services provided by OIB and OIL.

The key developments of HRT in 2024 comprise:

- **The 'Go live' of the preselection module**: since mid-June 2024, five internal competitions to the Commission have been published.
- **An operational HR Service Desk**: the Staff Contact service transitioned to the new solution in June 2024. All HR services have subsequently been introduced to the new tool.
- **An onboarding module**: the administrative onboarding of newcomers is being digitalised, starting with the entry into service process. The pilot solution went live in August 2024. It has allowed a group of Commission newcomers to be onboarded via this new digital platform.
- **Interinstitutional contributions**: most of the other EU institutions, bodies and agencies have signed the new HRT service level agreement appendix and have thus formalised their financial support of HRT development for the period 2024-2029. Roll-out pilot deployments have been started with the Council Secretariat for the HR Service Desk and for internal competitions.

1.5. Specific objective: Foster a secure workplace

DG HR continued to work with the Council to advance the negotiations on the proposed **information security regulation** in the ordinary legislative procedure. However, the Council has not yet adopted a General Approach.

DG HR prepared guidance to services on **information assessment** and categorisation, laying down general principles to be considered when assessing the information handled by each service. The guidance is addressed to the Local Security Officers, who may decide to adapt it further based on the particularities of the information handled by their respective services.

DG HR also worked on four **horizontal information security risks**, to gather experience and update the applicable corporate policies:

- Risks related to handling sensitive non-classified information in AI systems: DG HR coordinated a working group that drafted a security standard that will go to the Information Technology and Cybersecurity Board (ITCB) for adoption in Q2 2025.
- Risks related to quantum computing: DG HR ran a pilot project to evaluate the maturity of quantum proof encryption; it also organised workshops to raise awareness about the quantum risk and to disseminate the pilot results across the Commission. The findings will feed into the future corporate policy on mitigating the quantum risk.
- Outsourcing risks**:** DG HR reviewed the outsourcing principles; a new version of the outsourcing principles, including a detailed risk assessment, will be adopted during Q2 2025.
- External connections related risks: DG HR conducted a risk assessment regarding the way external connections are used to connect to the Commission's IT environment and proposed to DIGIT an approach to mitigate the risks.

Regarding **security-related processes**, in 2024, a new digital tool that allows users to manage their accounts (RUE-X) for EU classified information was rolled out successfully. The implementation of this digital tool continued to manage the security clearance process and replace the current case-handling system for internal investigations. These security processes will be handled through this new tool in Q2 2025.

In addition, DG HR continued to work on a draft proposal for a Commission decision on a **security clearance** requirement for certain categories of staff. It considers the need for proportionality and particularly a decision by the Court of Justice concerning the clearance regime of the European institutions and its impact on Member States' law.

In April 2024, DG HR launched a new **learning package addressed to Local Security Officers** (LSOs) and deputy LSOs in the Commission, executive agencies and JRC sites. The comprehensive package provides colleagues with relevant information to effectively perform their tasks and responsibilities. It simplifies the training process as most of the courses are in e-learning format, available at any moment and allowing maximum flexibility for completion.

2. INTERNAL CONTROL AND FINANCIAL MANAGEMENT

Management monitors the functioning of the internal control systems on a continuous basis and carries out an objective assessment of their efficiency and effectiveness. In Annex 7, there is a list and details of the reports that have been considered. The results of the above assessment are explicitly documented and reported to the Director-General.

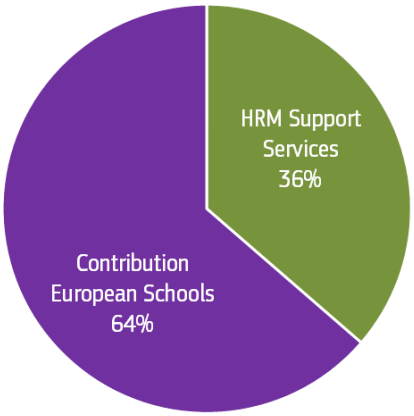
2.1. Control results

Management uses control results to support its assurance and reach a conclusion about the cost-effectiveness of those controls, meaning whether the right balance between the following elements is achieved:

- Effectiveness The level of error found, based on the controls carried out.
- Efficiency The average time taken to inform or pay.
- Economy The proportionality between the costs of controls and the funds managed.

2.1.1. Overview of the budget and relevant control systems (RCS)

In 2024, DG HR spent EUR 266 million (64%) in financial contribution for the European Schools and EUR 152 million (36%) in HR management (HRM) support services. The two relevant control systems (RCS) are embedded in procurement activities, financial transactions, revenues and supervisory measures. Annex 6 outlines the key risks and corresponding mitigating controls, while Annex 7 provides an overview of DG HR's budget, expenditure, and assurance-building process. The materiality criteria are presented in Annex 5.



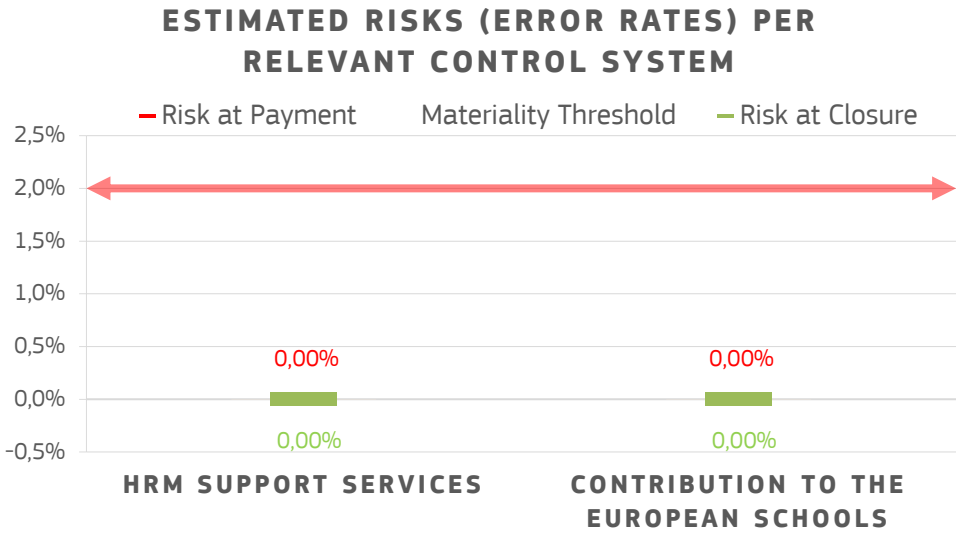
Beyond the initial allocated budget, additional funding was entrusted to DG HR for a total just over EUR 52 million. All budget allocations received from other entities were covered by the internal control system applied to DG HR expenditure. In 2024 DG HR incurred charges of EUR 32.9 million for services rendered on behalf of other DGs or services.

2.1.2. Effectiveness of controls

a) Assessment of control results per RCS for expenditure

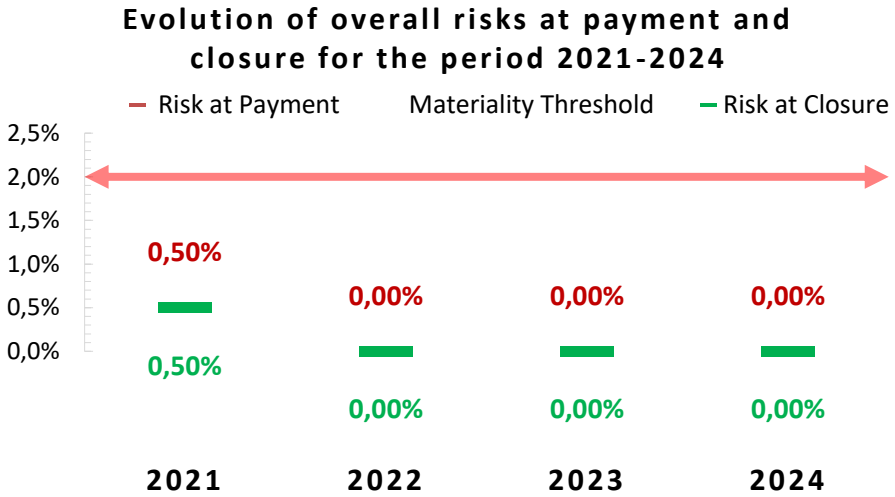
The ex post control campaign for 2024 covered 50 transactions worth EUR 83 million representing around 17% in respect of the value of payments and recoveries made by DG

HR ([15]). For both RCS, the results are an estimated error rate of 0%, in line with the results of the previous two years. More details can be found in Annex 7.



b) *Estimation of the overall risk at payment and risk at closure*

The estimated overall risk at payment for 2024 expenditure is the Authorising Officer's by Delegation (AOD) best conservative estimate of the amount of relevant expenditure during the year, not in conformity with the contractual and regulatory provisions applicable at the time the payment was made. This expenditure will subsequently be subject to ex post controls and a proportion of the underlying errors will be detected and corrected in subsequent years, corresponding to the conservatively estimated future corrections for 2024 expenditure. The difference between those two results in the estimated overall risk at closure ([16]).



([15]) See Annex 3, tables 2 (outturn on payment appropriations) and 7 (situation of revenue and income).

([16]) This is the AOD's best, conservative estimation of the expenditure authorised during the year that would remain not in conformity of applicable regulatory and contractual provisions by the end of implementation of the programme.

The ex post control results confirm the robustness of financial management in DG HR with an estimated error rate of 0% both, in line with results of previous years. As a result, the estimated risks at both payment and closure remain at 0% for the two Relevant Control Systems.

For an overview at Commission level, the departments' estimated overall risk at payment, estimated future corrections and risk at closure are consolidated in the Annual Management and Performance Report.

c) Quantitative benefits of controls: Preventive and corrective measures

With its ex ante and ex post controls, DG HR has an effective mechanism in place for detecting and correcting errors, reaching in total EUR 2.2 million of corrections for 2024. Ex ante controls resulted to EUR 0.6 million and ex post recoveries amounted to EUR 1.6 million. Please see details in Annex 3 table 8.

This is broadly in line with last year's figures - EUR 1.1 million and EUR 0.7 million respectively - despite a shift towards ex post controls. This shift was primarily driven by the identification and correction of unprovided services following operational implementation checks under complex contracts. While these recoveries appear as irregularities in reporting terms, they do not indicate a failure of the ex ante control system. Of the 1.6 million, the actual irregularities detected ex post are immaterial (amounting to less than 350 EUR). Other discrepancies identified ex ante mainly arose from inaccurate supplier reporting before payment, such as calculation errors or the inclusion of ineligible elements.

d) Assessment of control results for non-expenditure items

DG HR assets, as booked in the accounts (Annex 3), consist of internally developed Information Systems. They are thus intangible, non-current assets. For these assets, DG HR's main control objective is to ensure that confidential and/or sensitive information is not disclosed, or its integrity breached and that all relevant measures and procedures are applied to prevent and report any security breaches or leaks of personal and/or sensitive data. The indicator is the strict adherence to the provisions applicable to cases of data breach, which was met with no deviation in 2024 (DG HR fully complied with the procedure in place). None of the data breach in DG HR were considered large-scale breaches with significant impact. See more details in Section 3.

DG HR manages several IT systems that store personal data (e.g., Sysper, e-Sire, Stages, SerMed, HR Business Intelligence and HR Transformation). Some of DG HR's decision-making processes use, inter alia, reports based on data from these systems. The systems' security is monitored and improved when appropriate. The internal controls on IT security are effective, except for the remaining issues being corrected through the ongoing implementation of action plans from IAS audits (see section 2.2 and Annex 8 for more details). DG HR concludes that there are no major issues, whilst acknowledging that improvement actions are necessary and ongoing to address audit recommendations.

e) Fraud: prevention, detection, and correction

DG HR has developed and implemented its own anti-fraud strategy since 2013, based on the methodology provided by OLAF. The strategy is updated every three years, with the latest revision launched in 2024, involving a comprehensive review and a fraud risk assessment, and the new anti-fraud strategy set for adoption in early 2025. Its implementation is being monitored and reported to the management at least once a year. All necessary actions of the 2021 anti-fraud strategy have been implemented.

As co-lead service, DG HR has played a key role in the implementation of actions 11b (on information security), 40 (on ethics and anti-fraud training) and 44 (on recruitment process) of the Commission Anti-Fraud Strategy Action Plan of July 2023. Notable contributions include consistently supporting decentralised agencies in developing rules and guidance for handling EU Classified Information (EUCI) and sensitive non-classified information (e.g., delivering IT tools and tailored training for agency security staff), completing an internal mapping of existing ethics and anti-fraud training and integrating these into structured learning paths/packages and reviewing the recruitment processes to reinforce anti-fraud measures, with provisions for reassessment during future process updates.

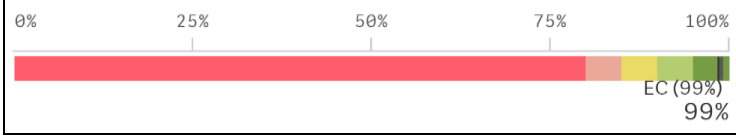
DG HR received one OLAF financial recommendation during the period 2020-2024. The recovery process is ongoing for a revised amount, based on additional evidence provided by OLAF. This revised recovery amount excludes sums linked to contracts managed by other institutions and unrelated to fraud or irregularities.

On the basis of the available information, DG HR has reasonable assurance that the anti-fraud measures in place are effective overall. Additional measures will be taken in the context of the new Anti-Fraud Strategy to improve the capacity of DG HR to tackle anti-fraud, including for example risks resulting from emerging technologies.

2.1.3. Efficiency of controls

The Financial Regulation requires reporting on three efficiency indicators, only one applicable to DG HR:

- **Time-to-pay** (Art. 116.6 FR), represented by the Commission standard "timely payments (%) indicator (the percentage of the amount paid on time – within the contractual payment deadline – on the overall amount paid), as reported in the Financial Scorecard (Annex 4).

Timely Payments	DG HR Score	EC Score
	99%	99%

DG HR paid virtually the whole amount on time, similarly to last years' results and performed in line with the Commission (EC) average. The high score was achieved through

streamlined payment workflows that ensured timely validation and approval of transactions. Regular monitoring helped prevent delays and quickly identified potential bottlenecks. Staff and authorising officers were well-informed of deadlines and best practices through awareness initiatives. Additionally, close collaboration between financial units and operational teams facilitated swift issue resolution. To sustain this success, DG HR will maintain strict monitoring and reporting, continue awareness initiatives, and try to further optimise processes through the new tool SUMMA.

All the other indicators included in the Financial Scorecard are in dark green (above 95%), with the exception of the Management Data Quality ([17]), reaching 86% (it was 71% in 2023). This result is due to a structural recurrent issue in the timely closure of purchase orders related to interimaire salaries expenditure. These orders have to be closed in bulk (as there are hundreds of transactions); however, the procedure cannot be completed by the end of the year and it is then completed at the beginning of January, without any significant impact on data quality.

DG HR concludes that the controls in place are operating efficiently.

2.1.4. Economy of controls

In 2024, DG HR estimated the costs of controls at around EUR 11.4 million, remaining broadly in line with 2023 (EUR 11.8 million). This represents 2.7% of the total payments, slightly down from 3.1% in 2023. The estimation is based on the cost of human resources dedicated to key financial control activities.

The cost of ex ante financial controls alone is estimated at around EUR 11.3 million, corresponding to 2.7% of total payments, while ex post financial controls account for 0.1% of verified transactions, amounting to around EUR 87 000.

Although the European Schools account for a large share of DG HR's expenditure, over 99% of all transactions concern other financial operations under the HRM support services. These transactions, while generally of low to medium value, require extensive ex ante checks in line with Financial Regulation and public procurement provisions. As a result, further cost reductions would jeopardize sound financial management, leading to risks that would require substantial efforts to mitigate. For more details, see Annex 7.

Relevant Control System	Cost of control	
	MEUR	% Payments
HRM support services	~EUR 11.12	**7.3%**
Contribution to the European Schools	~EUR 0.24	**0.1%**
Total Amount	**~EUR 11.36**	**2.7%**

([17]) This indicator measures the good data quality of ABAC transactions with the focus on fields having a primary impact on the management decisions.

The overall cost of controls is also assessed against their benefits, many of which are not quantifiable. Since controls primarily aim to prevent the negative consequences of inadequate oversight, estimating these avoided risks is inherently challenging or impossible. However, the benefits also include measurable outcomes, such as sound financial management - evidenced by a very low residual error rate - and financial gains from control measures ([18]).

Based on the above, the cost of controls is considered reasonable.

2.1.5. Conclusion on the cost-effectiveness of controls

No significant changes occurred in 2024 that impacted the control strategy and the two relevant control systems covering the implemented budget. The risk at both payment and closure remains well below the 2% materiality threshold, consistent with previous years – an outstanding achievement that reflects DG HR's commitment to sound financial management.

Regarding fraud prevention, detection, and correction, the 2021 DG anti-fraud strategy has been successfully implemented, and a new strategy is currently being adopted. For non-expenditure items, DG HR fully adhered to established procedures to prevent and report security breaches or leaks of personal and/or sensitive data. None of the recorded data breaches were classified as large-scale incidents with significant impact.

In terms of control efficiency, the available indicators continue to show excellent results, in line with previous years. Regarding cost-effectiveness, the control strategy maintains a global cost of controls below 3%, remaining stable over time.

Based on the most relevant key indicators and control results reported above, DG HR has assessed the effectiveness, efficiency and economy of its control system and reached a positive conclusion on the cost-effectiveness of the controls for which it is responsible.

2.2. Audit observations and recommendations

This section sets out briefly the state of play for all audit observations and recommendations reported by auditors related to internal control and financial management – including the limited conclusion of the Internal Auditor on the state of internal control. Further details for the Internal Audit Service (IAS) and the European Court of Auditors (ECA) audits can be found in Annex 8.

Where an audit has detected weaknesses affecting any internal control principle or the department's assurance, a detailed analysis is provided further below in sections 2.3 and 2.4, accordingly, and in Annex 8.

([18]) See the section on Quantitative benefits of controls (2.1.2.c) and Table 8 in Annex 3 for more information.

Internal Audit Service

In its contribution to the 2024 Annual Activity Report process, the IAS concluded that the internal control systems in place for the audited processes are effective, except for the observations giving rise to the 'very important' recommendations (RECs), summarised in the following table.

Reported	Audit Title	Accepted Recommendation	State of play in 2024	Impact on the assurance for 2024
2024	Assessment of HR needs in the Commission at corporate level (HR, BUDG, SG)	Very important: 1 & 4 (both new)	⏳	☑
2023	Protection of confidentiality of information at corporate level (HR, SG, DIGIT)	Very Important: 5 & 7 (not yet due), 9 (overdue)	⏳	☑
2022	Physical security of persons and assets in the Commission (HR, DIGIT, OIL, OIB, COMM)	Very Important: 1 & 3 (both overdue)	⏳	☑

☑ Action plan implemented and closed by IAS or ECA / No impact on the assurance
⏳ Action plan implementation is ongoing or awaiting review from IAS or ECA
📝 Preparation of the action plan
🚩 Impact on the assurance

In 2024, the IAS conducted an audit on the assessment of HR needs within the Commission, involving also DG BUDG and SG. The auditors issued two very important recommendations jointly addressed to the three DGs, focusing on support from corporate services for local-level assessments and quality checks of HR needs. A joint action plan was adopted by the three DGs, with DG BUDG leading the most significant actions. Substantial progress has already been made in addressing the recommendations, thereby mitigating the residual risk exposure, with the introduction of a revised Legislative Financial and Digital Statement (LFDS) to accompany each new legislative proposal. This sets out a much clearer framework for DGs, in which they can indicate which staff for a new initiative will be found via redeployment, and which cannot, aiding the overall assessment and quality checking process. Specifically, DG HR has implemented most of the actions within its remit, such as introducing new workload indicators and providing guidance on available tools for assessing workload, while also working on developments in the new HRT tool. Additionally, DG HR is cooperating with DG BUDG and SG on the remaining outstanding points.

Regarding the overdue recommendations arising from audits conducted in previous years, most of the sub-action points have been implemented. The remaining points are either near finalization or depend on decisions to be made at the corporate level. These delays have not resulted in significant risks, as several actions have been successfully completed, and other mitigating measures are in place to limit exposure. Consequently, there is no significant impact on the assurance (see Annex 8 for more details).

European Court of Auditors

The table below cover the new or outstanding recommendation(s) issued by the European Court of Auditors.

Notably, DG HR has no overdue recommendations. No recommendations were issued in the audit in respect of Statement of Assurance concerning administrative expenditure for the financial year 2023 and 2024.

Reported	Audit Title	Accepted Recommendation	State of play in 2024	Impact on the assurance for 2024
2024	Statement of Assurance (DAS)	None	✅	✅
2024	SR 24/2024 EU Civil service	1, 2, 3 (new)	⏳	✅
2023	SR 20/2023 on supporting persons with disabilities	4 (not yet due)	⏳	✅

✅ Action plan implemented and closed by IAS or ECA / No impact on the assurance
⏳ Action plan implementation is ongoing or awaiting review from IAS or ECA
📝 Preparation of the action plan
🚩 Impact on the assurance

In November 2024, the European Court of Auditors issued the Special Report 20/2024 on the EU Civil Service – A Flexible employment framework, insufficiently used to improve workforce management. The report included three recommendations addressed to the three audited Institutions (the European Commission, the European Parliament and the Council), all relevant to DG HR. In response, an action plan was developed, and DG HR is actively monitoring its implementation to ensure completion within the established target dates. The recommendations are not considered to have a significant impact on the assurance (see Annex 8 for further details).

2.3. Assessment of the effectiveness of internal control systems

The Commission has adopted an Internal Control Framework based on the highest international standards ([19]). DG HR has adapted the Internal Control Framework to their specific characteristics and organisational structure. The internal control systems are suited to achieving its policy and internal control objectives in accordance with the internal control principles, having due regard to the risks associated with the environment in which it operates.

DG HR has assessed its internal control system during the reporting year and has concluded that it is effective and the components and principles are present and functioning well overall, but some improvements are needed as minor deficiencies were identified related to outstanding IAS recommendations issued in the framework of the following engagements:

- Assessment of HR needs in the Commission at corporate level (two recommendations)
- Protection of confidentiality of information at corporate level (three recommendations)
- Physical security of persons and assets in the Commission (two recommendations).

The report for the first audit was issued in 2024, and the corresponding action plan, developed with SG and DG BUDG, is being implemented in accordance with the agreed timeline. Substantial progress has already been made in addressing the recommendations, thereby mitigating the residual risk exposure (see Section 2.2. and Annex 8 for further details). The reports for the remaining two audits were issued in earlier years, and their respective action plans are being actively implemented and monitored, in cooperation with

([19]) The Committee of Sponsoring Organizations of the Treadway Commission Internal Control Integrated Framework, the golden standard for internal control systems.

DG COMM, SG and DIGIT. Significant progress has been achieved; however, three recommendations have experienced delays, primarily due to factors beyond DG HR's control. These delays have not resulted in significant risks, as several actions have been successfully completed and other mitigating measures in place ensure limited exposure. Further details can be found in Section 2.2 and Annex 8.

2.4. Conclusions on the assurance

This section consolidates the assessment of the elements from previous sections 2.1, 2.2 and 2.3, summarising the sub-conclusions already reached. It presents an overall conclusion to support the declaration of assurance and determine whether any reservations are necessary

In general, the information in section 2 stems primarily from the results of management and auditor reviews, based on a systematic analysis of the available evidence. This approach provides sufficient guarantees as to the completeness and reliability of the reported information and results in a comprehensive coverage of the budget delegated to the Director-General of DG HR, as confirmed by the statement of the Director in charge of Risk Management and Internal Control in Annex 1.

No significant changes occurred in 2024 that impacted the control strategy and the two relevant control systems covering the implemented budget. The risk at both payment and closure remains well below the 2% materiality threshold, consistent with previous years—an outstanding achievement that reflects DG HR's commitment to sound financial management.

Regarding fraud prevention, detection, and correction, the 2021 DG anti-fraud strategy has been successfully implemented, and a new strategy is currently being adopted. For non-expenditure items, DG HR fully adhered to established procedures to prevent and report security breaches or leaks of personal and/or sensitive data. None of the recorded data breaches were classified as large-scale incidents with significant impact.

In terms of control efficiency, the available indicators continue to show excellent results, in line with previous years. Regarding cost-effectiveness, the control strategy maintains a global cost of controls below 3%, remaining stable over time. Throughout 2024, continuous efforts were made to address internal (IAS) and external (ECA) audit recommendations. Significant progress has been achieved in implementing the remaining open recommendations, and efforts will continue in 2025. However, the outstanding issues do not have a material impact on assurance, representing only minor areas for improvement in the internal control system.

In conclusion, based on the elements reported above, management has reasonable assurance that, overall, suitable controls are in place and working as intended; risks are being appropriately monitored and mitigated; and necessary improvements and reinforcements are being implemented. The Director-General, in his capacity as Authorising Officer by Delegation has signed the Declaration of Assurance.

2.5. Declaration of Assurance

I, the undersigned, Stephen Quest

Director-General of Human Resources and Security

In my capacity as authorising officer by delegation

Declare that the information contained in this report gives a true and fair view ([20]).

State that I have reasonable assurance that the resources assigned to the activities described in this report have been used for their intended purpose and in accordance with the principles of sound financial management, and that the control procedures put in place give the necessary guarantees concerning the legality and regularity of the underlying transactions.

This reasonable assurance is based on my own judgement and on the information at my disposal, such as the results of the self-assessment, ex post controls, the work of the Internal Audit Service and the lessons learnt from the reports of the Court of Auditors for years prior to the year of this declaration.

Confirm that I am not aware of anything not reported here which could harm the interests of the institution.

Brussels, 1 April 2025

Qualified electronic signature by: STEPHEN

PAUL JAMES QUEST

Date 2025-05-06 12:02:21 UTC

Stephen Quest

([20]) True and fair in this context means a reliable, complete and correct view on the state of affairs in the DG.

3. MODERNISING THE ADMINISTRATION

3.1. Human resource management

DG HR continued to actively implement the Commission HR strategy, while continuing to work towards its own target of returning 150 FTEs by the end of 2027. By 31 December 2024, a total of 100 FTEs had been returned to the central pool, i.e. two thirds of the target.

A management seminar was dedicated to putting a new AI tool into practice and in the area of well-being, 'help the helper' pilot training was offered to DG HR staff to better handle and prevent empathic distress fatigue.

The results of the 2023 staff survey provided an opportunity to take stock of key satisfaction indicators, including staff well-being. Overall, DG HR had very encouraging results: the participation rate increased with 19 percentage points and there was a record level of staff engagement (78%). In general, DG HR's averages were higher than those of the Commission as a whole and there were improvements in 15 of the 16 themes of the staff survey. Despite the challenges the DG has faced with implementing the new HR service model and the reduction of posts, there were excellent results in the field of teamwork and colleagues (90%).

In the follow-up to the staff survey, four major themes were identified: 1) well-being and work-life balance/working arrangements; 2) collaboration and communication; 3) senior management team; and 4) change and innovation. Staff-led working groups identified actions that will be implemented in 2025.

Other examples of staff engagement actions taken in 2024, were the launch of the monthly all-staff 'Question Hour' session (led by the Director-General) and the continuation of the DG HR Sounding Board launched in 2023, where a selected group of staff provide their insights and opinions on HR matters relating to DG HR staff. 2024 also saw the transition to a new local intranet on the SharePoint online platform, and the use of Viva Engage, around the theme of 'We are DG HR'.

At the end of 2024, 41% of middle managers were women. An improved balance is expected in 2025 when a number of currently vacant positions will be filled. DG HR also continued to make additional effort to enlarging its pool of potential female managers. It did so by appointing five women to Deputy Head of Unit positions, (bringing the total to 53%) and by encouraging women to follow the Female Talent Development Programme. The percentage of female Deputies to Directors remained stable at 43%.

Also, in the field of diversity, DG HR continued its efforts to improve geographical balance by implementing corporate measures.

3.2. Digital transformation and information management

In 2024, DG HR continued rolling out the Commission's new HR IT platform as an enabler of the HR strategy. The HRT programme applies the principle and goals of the corporate digital strategy as well as corporate architectural principles, such as cloud security. It stretches over seven years and will ensure full integration of HR service delivery to the new single platform ServiceNow.

The HRT programme is supported by several cross-cutting activities/themes such as data protection, IT security, digital architecture, and data governance. Regarding data architecture and data governance, the support for HRT focused on designing a business-based data model to ensure a stable and comprehensive implementation of HR business processes. The data model is built iteratively, aligned with the progress of individual HRT projects. Additionally, attention has been given to clarify and align business concepts and terms, across the HR Family. This activity enables a common implementation of a given business concept in multiple IT systems and enables integration and data reuse between IT systems and complies with the corporate 'once-only' data entry principle.

DG HR continued its effort in making progress on IT security plans, compliance attestations, multi-factor authentication and EU Login, as well as security assurance activities. This means that almost all information systems are covered by an up-to-date IT security plan, and almost all IT security controls have compliance attestation. Nearly all information systems are compliant with the ITCB decision regarding the use of multi-factor authentication and EU Login.

In 2024, DG HR continued to manage its information and knowledge better and to implement more collaborative working methods. This was done especially by individual and group coaching to middle and senior managers as key enablers to support the adoption of M365 tools and new ways of working.

To ensure the preparedness of staff to use the new platform in ServiceNow, many training sessions were provided to the case handlers, in particular to the time management case handlers and gradually to the various HR units.

With regard to the implementation of the Commission's Data Protection Action Plan, DG HR continued its efforts to raise awareness on data protection within DG HR. 70 staff members took part in data protection training during the year. Some 1 759 DG HR staff members participated in this training over the 2019-2024 period (out of 1 293 HR staff members - some participated more than once).

DG HR has continued to ensure that its processing operations are appropriately documented in data protection records, which are continuously reviewed and kept up to date on a bi-annual basis. DG HR has established agreements with external processors that process personal data on behalf of DG HR. In 2024, it replied to 37 requests from data subjects to exercise their data protection rights. DG HR's data protection coordinators delivered written data protection advice in 450 instances and provided 285 oral consultations.

Engagement of the business units in the corporate data governance activities continued in 2024. Responsibilities of specific data owners and data stewards were adapted to the progress of the HRT programme, to ensure appropriate handling of requests to sharing data between applications. Their feedback has been essential for improving this approval process. DG HR has also supported the Corporate Reference Data Management Working Group led by the Publications Office (OP) and SG to identify organisational-related reference data sets and to clarify their ownership.

3.3. Sound environmental management

The EMAS coordination team in DG HR coordinates the Commission Eco-Management and Audit Scheme (EMAS) and the implementation of the Greening the Commission Communication and action plan. It also promotes 'greening practice' among DG HR staff.

DG HR undertook the following greening actions in 2024:

- Promoting VeloMai among DG HR staff to encourage sustainable commuting practice;
- Opening some floors of L107 to use as a working 'hub' for colleagues choosing to come to work during the summer and the end-of-the-year energy saving actions (BEST);
- Being part of the pilot project on the collection and sorting of organic waste in the kitchenettes of the building L107;
- Setting up a collection of old clothes, textiles and sports equipment and a small biodiversity action with insect-friendly flowerpots, in collaboration with the 'EMAS Taskforce for the One' (together with DG SCIC and DG DIGIT) and a Clothes Swap event in collaboration with the Earth Society (EC Trainees' Association);
- Organising the annual DG HR Christmas party, based on, as far as possible, green principles, for example using recycled decorative materials and reusable glasses (instead of disposable plastic ones); and
- Encouraging all operational units to consult the Interinstitutional Green Public Procurement Helpdesk for their tenders.

The overall greenhouse gas emissions from DG HR staff's professional travel increased by 30% in 2024 compared to 2019. This is to a large part due to increased security-related missions in an evolving geopolitical context. Non-security-related missions from DG HR were reduced by 24%.

3.4. Examples of economy and efficiency

In 2024, DG HR continued examining its ways of working. It integrated the efficiency gains exercise launched in autumn 2023 in a larger approach with a particular focus on achieving the target of returning 150 FTEs to the central pool by the end of 2027.